

Episode 6: Once Upon a Time... (5) People Fighting from 11 PM

"I want to see *Odin: Photon Sailer Starlight*," I said, and thanks to Editor-in-Chief Oguro I was able to see it (Thank you, Editor-in-Chief Oguro!). So recently we held a mini-screening in the colour design room at Oizumi Studio. Several of us who were involved in finishing at the time watched it together.

"Ah, so this is what it was like," everyone said with distant stares (laughs). Based on *Yamato*-like elements, it tried to cram in all the trends of the time - animation, music, everything - but it was all half-hearted. That kind of feeling. "It was tough though (bitter laugh)" was everyone's impression (bitter laugh).

Well then.

The collaborative work *Robotex* story.

The animation and finishing work requested from Korean production companies came back about a week later on the final flight from Seoul.

At that time, the collaborative works being produced included *G.I. Joe*, *Transformer*, *Muppet Babies*, and several other lines. Packages from Korea arrived almost every night. Tonight Japanese staff, tomorrow night some Korean staff - someone's hand luggage, several duralumin trunks delivered to the studio.

20-30 kilogrammes each. Usually 2-3 pieces, sometimes 7-8 pieces. Those trunks and bags had travelled the Tokyo-Seoul route countless times, and like battle-scarred veterans, they were battered, wobbly, reinforced with duct tape everywhere, and used until they literally fell apart.

They'd paint until just before departure from Seoul production companies, hastily pack it, and give it to staff travelling to Tokyo. Even the carriers didn't know how many pieces of luggage there would be until the last minute. So the carrying staff had it

tough too. Occasionally, they'd miscount the pieces carried back from Narita Airport, leaving trunks abandoned at the baggage claim, causing great commotion (bitter laugh). Or sometimes luggage would be stopped by airport customs for some reason and couldn't be brought back - again, great commotion.

The final flights departing Seoul in the evening arrived at Narita Airport around 8:30-9:00 PM. After the long journey from there, they'd arrive at Oizumi Studio in Nerima around 11 PM. **And from there, it was war.**

Most of the arrived luggage was painted cels. The number of sheets coming back in one flight varied, but at peak times, all works combined could be over 3,000 sheets at once. We'd tackle them in order of schedule priority. Since it was so late, we'd want to say "Well, let's check tomorrow morning..." Works and episodes that could wait until the next day were worked on during the day. But works without schedule room would immediately unpack and start delivery checking (cel inspection and retake processing) to finish checking and retake processing by morning.

At that time, Toei Doga's [inspection] members totaled 10 people including me. Everyone had their own assigned works, but within their capacity for their own work, they participated in this late-night cel inspection as helpers.

For example, with *Robotex*, first I, as the person in charge, would quickly look through each cut and note any major mistakes like colour errors. Then several available helpers would divide up the cel inspection work.

As inspection progressed, we'd find all kinds of finishing-related retakes - colour mismatches, paint unevenness, more colour errors, mask creation mistakes, etc. Simple things we'd fix quickly while inspecting, but time-consuming ones got noted and passed to the retake processing team.

Late-night retake processing was handled by production companies specialising in finishing retakes. On nights with cel inspection, teams from those companies would come in around 11 PM when flights arrived, set up in the painting rooms. They'd eat sushi and such prepared by the finishing department while waiting for our inspection results, then process the mountain of retake cuts one after another.

So *Robotex* Episode 1 came back painted this way. The luggage arrived, progress staff skillfully took out cut bags from trunks and sorted them by work. Matching shipping slips with luggage, finally the mountain of *Robotex* painted work was piled in front of me. **Now, checking begins.**

"Aggh!"

Opening the first cut, I was immediately stunned. There should have been a white-bodied robot with black surface shadows in white-black two-tone colour, but the cel I held had just a solid white mass painted uniformly white. The shadow areas that should have been painted separately had been omitted and painted "shadowless." "Oh no," an immediate baptism.

Also, several characters running toward the background, who should have been different colours, were all painted the same colour (naturally shadowless), or painted in completely unspecified colours...

This was common with Korean deliveries at the time - when there was no schedule room and they absolutely had to make the final flight that day, sometimes this kind of "work simplification" or "work time reduction" would be imposed.

Some cuts even had paint that wasn't properly dry, sticking to the animation paper - "half-dry" cels... (cries).

"Ah, ah, ah... (sweat)" I panicked. But I couldn't OK this as-is, so retakes it was. I added processing instructions and sent them to the retake team. Various time-consuming cuts and cuts with complex retake instructions I decided to handle myself, while requesting help from assisting seniors for other OK-looking cuts or cuts without major retakes.

In the "tissue paper" (white protective paper on cels) covering the floor like clouds, cel inspection proceeded silently. As expected from battle-tested seniors. The large pile soon disappeared. When the assisted portions were finished, the seniors went home. **What remained were me, the work's person in charge, and the retake team fighting the mountain of retakes.**

While checking remaining cuts, I reflected.

"See, this is why mistakes happen when you specify like this."

F-san, the senior who helped with inspection, had pointed out several problems with my colour direction method.

Thinking about it, these shadow-skipped cuts might have happened because I hadn't properly written "BL" instructions for the BL shadow parts, and everyone being painted the same colour might have been problems with my colour direction method. Being painted random colours might have been because when inquiries came, my response was delayed, so they couldn't make it in time... The more I thought, the more I concluded, "Ah, maybe it was the fault of me, the rookie?" If proper, clear, accurate specifications had been given, they might have painted it properly, and we might not have had to process retakes until this hour...

While reflecting on various things like this, cuts flowed to photography like a raging torrent. This continued for about 3 days. The final retake processing finished at 6 AM on the last day. 12 hours later, all the rushes were completed, and all staff

watched that connected film together. There we found several major retakes, rushed to fix those too and re-shot. Thus *Robotex* Episode 1 was somehow shipped to America.

Finally taking a breath... but there was no time for that, as Episode 2's cuts waiting for colour direction were already piled like a mountain on my desk.

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